

After your bone graft

RECOVERY GUIDE · SOCKET PRESERVATION & RIDGE AUGMENTATION

Keep this guide handy
Call our office with any questions

A bone graft rebuilds or preserves the bone where a tooth was lost, so there is enough support for a future implant, bridge, or denture. The graft is made of small bone particles, usually covered by a thin membrane that holds them in place while your own bone grows through them. Nothing is locked in on day one — your main job for the first few weeks is to leave the site completely alone. If another handout in your packet gives a shorter time for the same rule, follow this guide. Here's what to expect and what to do.

TODAY	DAYS 2–3	WEEKS 1–2	MONTHS 3–4+
Rest. Gauze. Ice. Soft, cool foods. Don't touch the site.	Swelling peaks. A few graft grains in your saliva is normal.	Gums close over. Sutures dissolve.	Graft matures into your own bone. We plan the implant or restoration.

1 The first 24 hours

PROTECT THE SITE

A blood clot forms around the graft and holds the particles in place while healing starts. Losing it early can cost you part of the graft.

- ✗ No rinsing, swishing, or spitting for 24 hours — let saliva gently drain
- ✗ No straws, no vaping, no sucking motions for 72 hours
- ✗ Don't touch the site with your tongue or finger
- ✗ Don't pull your lip or cheek back to look at it — that tugs on the stitches

BLEEDING

Bite gently but steadily on gauze for 30–45 minutes. Oozing and pink saliva for the first day is normal.

 **If bleeding restarts:** fold a fresh gauze (or a damp black tea bag — the tannins help) over the site, bite steadily without checking for 30 minutes, and keep your head elevated.

ICE FOR SWELLING

- 20 minutes on, 20 minutes off, for the first 24 hours
- Swelling peaks at 48–72 hours, not the day of surgery
- After 48 hours, switch to warm moist compresses
- Bruising on the cheek or jaw is normal and can appear days later

EAT SOFT, COOL FOODS — ON THE OTHER SIDE

GOOD CHOICES

- ✓ Yogurt, cottage cheese, pudding
- ✓ Smoothies (spoon only — no straw)
- ✓ Mashed potatoes, applesauce
- ✓ Scrambled eggs, soft pasta
- ✓ Lukewarm soup, broth

AVOID FOR AT LEAST A WEEK

- ✗ Hot temperatures (can restart bleeding)
- ✗ Hard, crunchy, chewy foods
- ✗ Chips, nuts, popcorn, rice, seeds — they lodge in the site
- ✗ Carbonated drinks
- ✗ Chewing on the graft side

REST

No exercise, heavy lifting, or strenuous activity for at least 72 hours — elevated blood pressure can restart bleeding. Sleep with your head elevated on an extra pillow the first few nights.

Protecting the graft while it heals

BONE GRAFT RECOVERY · CONTINUED

2 The rules that matter most

The graft particles take weeks to knit together. Until then, pressure, suction, and scrubbing can shift them.

- ✗ **No smoking or smokeless tobacco for 1 month.** Nicotine constricts blood vessels and slows bone healing — it is the habit most likely to make a graft fail.
- ✗ **Don't push on the graft with your tongue.**
- ✗ **Don't brush directly over the graft site,** and keep electric toothbrushes and Waterpiks away from it until we clear you at your follow-up.
- ✗ **No vigorous rinsing for 7 days.** Gentle rinses only — let the water fall out of your mouth.
- ✗ **Don't wear a denture, partial, or flipper over the site** until we've adjusted it. Pressure can disturb the graft.
- ✗ **No alcohol for 7 days.**

i About the graft particles: you may see small whitish-gray grains at the site — that's graft material. Don't pick at them. A few grain-like bits in your saliva over the first few days is normal and expected; you don't need to save them.

3 Your membrane

A membrane covers the graft to hold it in place and keep gum tissue from growing into it. We use one of two kinds — we'll tell you which you have.

COLLAGEN (DISSOLVING)

- Dissolves on its own over a few weeks
- May look like a whitish film at the site
- Don't pull at it, even if an edge lifts

PTFE (NON-DISSOLVING)

- Looks like a white or gray patch; a small exposed edge is normal
- We remove it at a short visit — usually about 2 weeks after surgery, sometimes 4
- Don't pick at it or try to remove it yourself

 Sometimes the membrane comes untucked or even comes all the way out. Please give us a call if it does.

4 Rinsing & hygiene

- **Peridex (chlorhexidine) soak — morning and night.** Hold a capful over the site for 1 minute, then let it fall out. Don't swish. Start 2 days before surgery and continue for 1 week after. Nothing to eat or drink for 30 minutes afterward.
- **Weeks 2 and 3: switch from the soak to a swab.** Dip a cotton swab (Q-tip) in the Peridex until it's saturated and gently wipe it along the stitch line, morning and night. Don't scrub. This keeps the incision clean without staining the rest of your teeth — Peridex stains with longer use, and a swab only touches the spot that needs it.
- **Saltwater, starting tomorrow.** Mix ½ tsp salt in 8 oz warm water. Rinse gently 3–4× daily, especially after meals, and let it fall out of your mouth.
- **Brush the rest of your teeth** normally starting tomorrow with a soft manual brush. After day 3, you can clean gently near — but not on — the site.
- **Sutures** dissolve on their own over 7–10 days. Don't pull, pick, or cut them. If non-dissolving sutures were placed, we remove them at your follow-up.

5 What's normal vs. what's not

NORMAL (EXPECTED)

- ✓ A few graft grains in your saliva the first few days
- ✓ Swelling peaking at days 2–3, then daily improvement
- ✓ Whitish film or patch over the site (membrane or healing tissue)
- ✓ Slight bad taste for a few days
- ✓ Stitches loosening as they dissolve

CALL OUR OFFICE

- ✗ The membrane comes untucked or comes out
- ✗ Pain or swelling getting *worse* after day 3, or returning after you'd improved
- ✗ Pus, or a bad taste that comes back after improving
- ✗ Bleeding that won't stop after 30–45 min of steady pressure
- ✗ Fever over 101°F

URGENT — DON'T WAIT

- Difficulty breathing or swallowing
- Rapidly spreading swelling to your neck, under your tongue, or around your eye

Call our office right away for the on-call provider. If you truly cannot breathe or swallow, call 911.

6 Healing time & follow-up

Your first follow-up visit is scheduled before you leave the office — timing depends on your case. For pain, a combination of **ibuprofen + acetaminophen** works as well as prescription opioids for most dental pain — see your **Medication Guide**. If you were given an antibiotic, finish the full course.

A socket graft takes about **3–4 months** to mature into solid bone before an implant can be placed. Larger ridge grafts take longer — we'll give you your timeline at your follow-up.

Most of what protects your graft is simply leaving it alone. If something doesn't look or feel right, call us — a quick check is always easier than rebuilding a graft.

Acknowledgment & signature

I acknowledge that I have received and understand these instructions, and all my questions have been answered. I agree to follow them and to call the office with any questions or concerns.

PATIENT SIGNATURE

DATE

PATIENT PRINTED NAME

DATE OF BIRTH

PARENT / LEGAL GUARDIAN / CAREGIVER SIGNATURE (IF SIGNING FOR THE PATIENT)

DATE

PRINTED NAME

RELATIONSHIP TO PATIENT